

ASPARAGUS *Asparagus officinalis*

Asparagus is a valuable crop, yielding succulent produce that is costly to buy, at a time of year when little else is available. It has a reputation for being difficult to grow, but modern high-yielding, high-quality cultivars are available and make success much easier; all-male varieties now dominate, since they produce a greater number of thicker spears. Two years must elapse before the first crop, but the wait is well worth it.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING AND PLANTING

Any fertile, well-drained garden soil in full sun will support asparagus. Dig in plenty of well-rotted manure or compost shortly before planting, and consider adding lime to the soil if it is acidic; asparagus does best with a pH between 6.3–7.5.

If you are raising asparagus from seed, sow it indoors in late winter. Sow singly in module trays and keep warm using a heated propagator. The seedlings can be planted out in late spring.

However, most gardeners buy dormant asparagus crowns and plant them directly into the ground in early spring. Dig trenches 8 in (20 cm) deep and incorporate fertilizer into the base. Set the plants in the soil



Spread the roots on the trench base.

in the bottom of the trench. Although close planting is possible, allowing 16 in (40 cm) between crowns and 4 ft (1.2 m) between trenches will give a longer lasting plantation.

CROP CARE

Asparagus plants should be well watered and fed with a balanced fertilizer every spring. Once established, no further